

("Repeating" or "Teaching"). Completed in c. 200 CE by Rabbi Judah Ha-Nasi, the book is the oldest part of the Talmud. Based on the oral tradition of the Pharisees, the Mishnah is divided into six seder (orders). These, in turn, are subdivided into between seven and twelve tractates (books), which cover every part of Jewish life. One of these tractates, *Pirkei Avot* (*Sayings of the Fathers*), traced the oral tradition through a line of authorities all the way back to Moses in Sinai.

Building a virtual temple

The subject of the Mishnah's fifth order, Kodashim, was the Temple of Jerusalem. The writers lovingly described every detail of the lost building and of the sacrificial process. This was so that temple worship could continue to be at the center of Jewish religious life. According to the Talmud, "He who engages in study of the laws of sacrifice should be regarded as if he had offered up a sacrifice himself." Since 70 CE, Jews have prayed daily for the Temple to be restored by God and for worship to resume there—so study of the Temple was also a



This page of a printed Talmud shows the Mishnah and Gemara in the center (in larger type), medieval commentaries known as the Tosafot ("Additions") on the left, and Rashi's commentary along with notes by later scholars on the right.

8th century, the city of Córdoba became a center of Jewish learning. Halakha (Jewish law, derived from the Talmud) influenced the development of Sharia (Islamic law).

Unlike Christianity, whose laws were made by councils or synods, Jewish and Muslim laws were derived through scholarship. Both systems regulate every part of daily life, and both combine laws based on a divinely inspired book (the Torah and Koran, respectively) with later oral traditions.

The Talmud on trial

From Spain, the Talmud spread to Christian Europe, where schools were established in major cities. Europe's rulers knew nothing about the Talmud, assuming that Jews only studied the Torah of Moses.

In 1238, Nicholas Donin, a French Jew who had converted to Christianity and became a

way of preparing for the future. Alongside the Mishnah, the Talmud includes the Gemara ("Completion"), a much longer commentary written by later rabbis in Aramaic, which was the everyday spoken language at the time. Two different Gemaras were created: a Palestinian version, compiled between 350 and 400 CE, and a Babylonian one, written between 350 and 550 CE. The latter version is much longer and is seen as having greater authority.

The Gemara is a vast body of diverse material that explores the meaning of the laws outlined in the Mishnah and their application in daily life. Unlike most law codes, it often presents contradictory rulings by rabbis side by side without deciding between them. Rather than fixing Jewish law, the Gemara enabled it to be studied and argued over, and has been described as the first interactive text.

The Babylonian Talmud (made up of the Mishnah and the Babylonian Gemara) spread widely within the Islamic world, where Jews had a protected status. Following the Muslim conquest of Spain in the

Moses received the Torah at Sinai and transmitted it to Joshua ... the elders to the prophets, and the prophets to the Men of the Great Assembly.

Pirkei Avot

O dreadful and terrible day ... Sun and Moon are darkened, the heavens shattered, the stars driven away ... the universe mourns.

Hebrew account of the trial of the Talmud